

Ἴππωνάξ ὁ Ἐφέσιος

Exile and Invective in the Verse of Hipponax of Ephesus

eul_aid: bek

Period: Ἀρχαϊκή [Archaic](#)
Dialect: Ἴωνική Ἰαμβική [Ionic Iambic](#)
Domain: Ποίησις [Poetry](#)
Format: Ἑμμετρος [Verse](#)

Hipponax of Ephesus was an iambic poet active in the sixth century BCE. Exiled from his native city, he settled in Clazomenae. His poetry constructs a persona defined by poverty and misfortune. Ancient sources report he used his verse for vicious personal attacks, most famously claiming he drove the sculptor Bupalus to suicide.

His work survives only in fragments. Hipponax is credited with inventing the scazon, or choliambic meter, a limping iambic trimeter suited to his abusive tone. Composed in the Ionic dialect, the fragments feature explicit invective, scatological humor, and themes of beggary and theft.

A foundational figure in the Greek iambic tradition of blame poetry, Hipponax, alongside Archilochus, established invective as a core poetic mode. His choliambic meter influenced later satirical poetry, including the Hellenistic mimes of Herodas. His fragments provide a valuable glimpse into the coarse, personal dimensions of Archaic Greek literature.

Works (1)

- Ἀπόσπασμα · [Fragment 128](#) · 320 passages